online space has to challenge the national narrative and critique the actions of the security state that threatens the security establishment. The role of social media in the Arab Spring, in the way it helped spread the message and assisted young activists in mobilizing support, turns it into a thorn in the side of the security establishment. Its role in promoting PTM in Pakistan is another instance where social media has the potential of mobilizing citizens. This is particularly true in instances where political parties have been using social media to promote their message: the use of Twitter by individuals like Maryam Nawaz, the daughter of Nawaz Sharif and his predicted heir, in her criticism of Panamagate and her father's dismissal (and her sudden silence); the use of social media by political parties such as the PTI to spread its agenda and mobilize young people for its rallies (Yusaf 2016; Kolsy 2013; Farooq 2014). Even in India, Kanungo (2015) observes how the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) used social media in the 2014 Lok Sabha elections, arguing that while it was important it was not necessarily a 'game changer'. Similarly, Ullah (2013) argues for its potential in Bangladesh where youth engagement on social media may not directly influence 'political decision-making' but could play a role in the 'policy-making process'. While it is unclear the extent to which social media impacts political participation of young people, Kahne and Bowyer's research on social media and participatory politics in the United States found that a connection between 'offline political activity to online participatory politics was statistically significant' in their research, compared to 'online participatory politics to offline political activity', which, though 'positive', was 'not statistically significant' (2018, p. 490). It is clear that young people who are already politically active become better organized through online activity; the question still remains to what extent are politically inactive people encouraged to become active offline. However, in Pakistan the disconnect between online activism and offline participation in political rallies or movements is evident in the fact that often only a fraction of the individuals who agree to take part in such rallies online actually show up to the event, once again indicative of Howard et al.'s 'slacktivism' hypothesis (2016).

For the majority of the participants then, the main role of social media sites such as Facebook was simply networking with friends and family, socializing through posting photographs or following celebrities, or simply as '*time pass*', that is, a medium of procrastination (Student, Male, Kanganpur). Only a handful (8 in total) from the 2015–16 sample did not use Facebook because they felt it was a waste of time. More problematic was the idea that Facebook was a useful source of news about the country and the world: '*Yes, we get most*